

QuickShop

Reducing weekly grocery friction through personalised basket building

Role

Senior Product Designer

Company

Waitrose & Partners

Timeline

10 weeks

Focus

Personalisation / Behavioural UX / AI-assisted commerce

Overview

Weekly grocery shopping is repetitive.

Most customers buy a large percentage of the same products every week, yet online grocery experiences still relied heavily on:

- repeated searching
- category navigation
- manual basket building
- decision-heavy browsing

At Waitrose, we explored how personalisation and behavioural prediction could reduce friction by helping customers rebuild their regular shops faster.

I led the design of QuickShop — a personalised basket-building experience designed to surface highly relevant products using behavioural data, recommendation confidence and adaptive shopping patterns.

The goal wasn't discovery.

It was reducing effort for repeat purchasing.

Why this mattered

Online grocery shopping involves high-frequency repeat behaviour.

Research showed customers regularly repurchased:

- staple groceries
- household essentials
- recurring weekly products
- familiar brands

However, rebuilding a weekly basket still required significant manual effort.

This created several challenges:

- repetitive shopping journeys
- slower basket completion
- unnecessary cognitive load
- reduced efficiency for loyal customers

The opportunity was clear:

Could we reduce the effort of weekly shopping by intelligently surfacing the products customers were most likely to buy?

The problem

Most online grocery experiences treated every shopping session as a new browsing experience.

But grocery shopping behaviour is highly habitual.

Customers often wanted to:

- repeat previous behaviour
- replenish essentials quickly
- complete routine shopping efficiently

Traditional navigation patterns forced users to:

- repeatedly search for known products
- move across multiple categories
- rebuild baskets from scratch

This created friction in an experience that should feel predictable and effortless.

The challenge became:

How might we intelligently streamline repeat shopping behaviour without overwhelming customers or reducing confidence?

Behavioural insights

Grocery shopping is deeply habitual

Customers consistently purchased recurring products on predictable cycles.

Patterns emerged around:

- weekly staples
- household products
- repeat brand preferences
- replenishment timing

This created strong opportunities for predictive personalisation.

Customers valued speed over exploration during repeat shops

When completing regular weekly shops, many customers prioritised:

- efficiency
- familiarity
- predictability

rather than browsing or discovery.

The experience needed to reduce unnecessary interaction overhead.

Over-personalisation created friction

Testing showed customers became frustrated when recommendations felt:

- irrelevant
- overly broad
- difficult to scan

Customers responded more positively when recommendations felt:

- highly relevant
- structured
- transparent
- confidence-driven

This became a critical design consideration throughout the experience.

Hypothesis

We believed that if we could:

- identify highly predictable shopping behaviour
- prioritise confidence-based recommendations
- simplify basket rebuilding
- and structure recommendations around customer mental models

...we could significantly reduce friction and increase repeat-purchase efficiency.

Design principles

Prioritise confidence over quantity

Highly relevant recommendations were more valuable than large recommendation sets.

Reduce decision fatigue

The experience should minimise unnecessary browsing and searching.

Reflect natural shopping behaviour

Customers think in routines, categories and replenishment patterns — not algorithmic outputs.

Keep the experience lightweight

The interaction model needed to feel fast, focused and easy to scan.

Exploring recommendation models

A major part of the project focused on testing different interaction models for personalised basket building.

We explored three distinct concepts.

Concept 1 — Joy Scrolling

A continuous feed of recommended products displayed within a single long page.

The goal was to create a lightweight, effortless browsing experience.

However, testing revealed several issues:

- customers struggled to maintain context
- recommendations felt overwhelming
- category switching created friction
- lower-confidence products reduced trust

The experience felt algorithmically heavy rather than behaviourally intuitive.

Concept 2 — Step-by-Step Shopping

A structured basket-building experience organised into focused stages.

Recommendations were grouped into categories such as:

- Top Regulars
- Food & Drink
- Household & More
- Inspirational Meals

This aligned more closely with customer mental models and significantly improved comprehension.

Customers described the experience as:

- faster
- clearer
- easier to trust
- more predictable

The structured approach reduced cognitive overload while maintaining recommendation relevance.

Concept 3 — Netflix-Style Navigation

A vertically stacked interface using horizontal product carousels grouped by recommendation themes.

While the model improved category separation, testing revealed:

- excessive scanning behaviour
- fragmented focus
- reduced comparison clarity
- weaker progression through basket building

Customers preferred the clearer structure of the Step-by-Step model.

The solution

The final direction focused on a simplified Step-by-Step basket-building experience.

Recommendations were prioritised using behavioural confidence scoring and grouped into structured categories aligned with shopping habits.

The experience surfaced:

- highly predictable repeat purchases
- household staples
- personalised product suggestions
- category-specific recommendations

...within a fast and lightweight interaction flow.

Top Regulars

The experience prioritised products with strong repeat-purchase confidence.

These products formed the foundation of the basket-building experience.

Customers could:

- quickly add essentials
- adjust quantities
- skip products easily
- rebuild baskets rapidly

This reduced the need for repetitive manual searching.

Structured recommendation groups

Recommendations were intentionally grouped around behavioural patterns rather than algorithmic outputs.

This created:

- stronger comprehension
- reduced scanning fatigue
- improved confidence
- clearer shopping progression

The structure helped customers feel guided rather than overwhelmed.

Lightweight interaction design

The experience was intentionally designed to feel:

- fast
- focused
- low-effort

Interaction patterns prioritised:

- quick selection
 - minimal decision-making
 - rapid progression
 - easy basket refinement
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Key product decisions

We prioritised recommendation confidence over volume

Large recommendation sets reduced trust and increased cognitive load.

Surfacing fewer, more relevant products created stronger customer confidence.

We avoided endless recommendation feeds

Continuous recommendation feeds created scanning fatigue and reduced orientation.

Structured progression aligned more closely with grocery shopping behaviour.

We designed around behavioural patterns, not categories alone

Customers think in routines and replenishment behaviour.

Grouping recommendations around shopping intent improved usability significantly.

We shipped a focused MVP

Although broader recommendation structures tested positively, the initial MVP focused on Top Regulars.

This allowed the team to:

- validate behavioural assumptions quickly

- reduce implementation complexity
 - accelerate delivery
 - prioritise future AI-assisted shopping initiatives
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Validation & iteration

The concepts were tested with customers across different shopping behaviours and levels of online grocery familiarity.

Structured flows increased confidence

Customers responded positively to the Step-by-Step model because it:

- reduced overwhelm
 - improved clarity
 - created stronger progression
 - aligned with existing shopping habits
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Recommendation transparency mattered

Trust improved when recommendations felt:

- understandable
- relevant
- behaviourally logical

Poorly matched recommendations reduced confidence quickly.

Simplicity outperformed novelty

While more exploratory browsing models appeared visually engaging, customers ultimately prioritised:

- speed
- predictability
- efficiency

for routine shopping tasks.

Impact

Reduced basket-building friction

The experience streamlined repeat shopping behaviour by surfacing highly relevant products earlier.

Increased repeat-purchase efficiency

Customers could rebuild regular baskets significantly faster using confidence-based recommendations.

Established behavioural recommendation frameworks

The project helped define how:

- personalisation
- recommendation confidence
- behavioural prediction
- adaptive shopping patterns

could scale across future grocery experiences.

Created foundations for AI-assisted commerce

QuickShop established early frameworks for more intelligent grocery experiences centred around:

- behavioural understanding
 - predictive shopping
 - adaptive recommendation systems
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Reflection

The most important learning was that personalisation alone does not reduce friction.

Recommendations only became valuable when they:

- aligned with customer expectations
- felt highly relevant
- reduced cognitive effort
- maintained customer confidence

The project shifted the focus from:

“How do we recommend more products?”

to:

“How do we make routine shopping feel effortless?”

Designing for repeat grocery behaviour required balancing:

- prediction with clarity
- speed with trust
- automation with human shopping habits

The result was a more structured and behaviourally intelligent shopping experience designed around real customer routines.

Core skills demonstrated

- Product strategy
- Behavioural UX
- Recommendation systems
- AI-assisted commerce
- Systems thinking
- Personalisation design
- Interaction design
- Information architecture
- User research
- Rapid prototyping
- A/B testing
- Cross-functional collaboration
- Data-informed design
- E-commerce optimisation